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Virendra Saklani/Gulf News

UAE RESIDENTS EMBRACE FESTIVE CHEER

A giant Christmas tree takes pride of place at Wafi City in Dubai as festive spirit shines bright across the UAE. With stunning decorations, lively bazaars and festive offerings, the UAE promises something for every age group.

Scan the QR code for the video of the festive displays



38 Palestinians killed in Gaza amid new ceasefire hopes

Deal to halt fighting and release hostages likely soon: Officials

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N R

Senior Associate Editor

At least 38 people have been killed and 203 wounded in Israeli attacks across Gaza over the past 24 hours, amid optimism from rival camps about a potential ceasefire deal.

Hamas said yesterday's talks in Qatar, aimed at achieving a truce and a hostage-prisoner exchange in Gaza, were "serious and positive", while Israeli of-

ficials described a ceasefire as more realistic now than at any time in the past year. Parties involved in long-stalled ceasefire discussions suggested that a deal to halt the fighting and release hostages held in Gaza could be secured soon.

A working group from Israel is currently in Doha to re-establish relations with mediators in case of a breakthrough in negotiations with Hamas, according to Israeli officials.

Gaza's civil defence agency reported that Israeli strikes across the territory on Monday killed at least 38 people, most of them displaced Palestinians seeking shel-

ter in a house in the north. Civil defence spokesperson Mahmud Bassal said 10 Palestinians were killed in a dawn strike on a house in Beit Lahia, northern Gaza.

Israel will occupy Syria buffer zone: Netanyahu

Meanwhile, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu announced that Israeli troops would continue to occupy a recently seized buffer zone in Syria for the foreseeable future, even as ceasefire efforts in Gaza persist. Netanyahu made the statement on Tuesday night while touring Mount Hermon, known to Syrians as Jabal Shaikh.

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Now, residents can 'bus pool' in Dubai

To hop on, you will need to book a ride through an app

DUBAI

Gulf News Report

Residents in Dubai can now "bus pool" to their destination by sharing minibus rides through a booking system on smart apps, it was announced yesterday.

The seating capacity of these buses range from 13 to 30 passengers. The fare will be variable, based on the distance travelled and demand for the service. Additionally, the service provides passengers with options for single trips or weekly and monthly subscriptions.

Ahmad Hashim Bahrozian, CEO of Public Transport Agency of the Roads and

Transport Authority (RTA), said the service operates without fixed routes unlike public buses. Initially, it will be available in Deira, connecting to central business districts such as Business Bay, Dubai Mall, Mirdif, and Dubai Festival City. The plan is to gradually expand the service to cover all parts of the emirate.

The minibuses will operate on demand, with bookings facilitated through three smart applications - Citylink Shuttle, DrivenBus, and Fluxx Daily - with each company operating and managing 20 minibuses through the designated apps, said Bahrozian.

"This initiative aims to provide licensed transport options for passengers, encouraging them to use authorised means of transport instead of unlicensed alternatives," he added.

NATION

Meet the
cadet pilots
who earned
wings to fly
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Boost for UAE borrowers on third rate cut

US FED PENCILS IN TWO 0.25% CUTS IN 2025, DOWN FROM FOUR SEEN EARLIER

DUBAI

BY JUSTIN VARGHESE

Your Money Editor

The US Federal Reserve expectedly cut interest rates by 25 basis points in its third straight interest rate cut since Covid-19, but only pencilled in two quarter-point cuts in 2025, signalling greater caution over how quickly they can continue reducing borrowing costs.

US policymakers voted 11-to-1 to lower the US central bank's key lending rate to between 4.25 per cent and 4.50 per cent. They also pencilled in just two quarter-point rate cuts for next year, and sharply hiked their inflation outlook for 2025.

New quarterly forecasts showed several officials pencilling in fewer rate cuts for next year than they estimated just a few months ago. They now see their benchmark rate reaching a range of 3.75 per cent to 4 per cent by the end of 2025.

Investors had baked in expectations that the Fed will announce a quarter percentage-point yesterday.

The latest rate cut builds on the Fed's action in November

and September, when it kicked off its easing cycle with a large reduction of half a percentage-point, and pencilled in additional cuts for this year.

CBUAE cuts rate

Shortly after the Fed's announcement, the UAE Central Bank too decided to cut the base rate applicable to the Overnight Deposit Facility (ODF) by 25 basis points from 4.65 per cent to 4.40 per cent, effective from today.

"This decision was taken following the US Federal Reserve's announcement to reduce the Interest Rate on Reserve Balances (IORB) by 25 basis points," the Central Bank of the UAE said in a statement.

"The CBUAE has also decided to maintain the interest rate applicable to borrowing short-term liquidity from the CBUAE at 50 basis points above the base rate for all standing credit facilities," it said.

The base rate, which is anchored to the US Federal Reserve's IORB, signals the general stance of monetary policy and provides an effective floor for overnight money market interest rates in the UAE.

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